

South East Technological University

“FOCUS” – Learning to See Again

*A short film about loss and healing, developed using DaVinci Resolve
and the Adobe Creative Suite.*

BSc (Hons) in Creative Computing

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Declaration of Authenticity



Except where explicitly stated, this report represents my work that I have done myself. I have not submitted the work represented in this report in any other course of study leading to an academic award.

Abstract

“FOCUS” – Learning to See Again

“Healing isn’t about forgetting someone — it’s learning to see the world they loved through your own eyes.”

This short film presents a reflective narrative story following a young adult, Ella. It follows Ella’s journey of healing through the art of memory (Martinez, 2020). Ella has lost her mentor, her close friend Liam. Liam was deeply important to Ella, as he inspired her passion for photography.

After Liam has left her life, Ella’s passion for photography fades. Her camera starts to gather dust on a shelf as the world turns muted and colourless around her.

When Ella stumbles across an old memory card, which she discovers once belonged to Liam, she discovers moments captured by Liam through the lens of his camera, of Ella when she was still bright and vibrant. She sees herself and her surroundings through Liam’s perspective.

As Ella revisits the places and memories she once shared with Liam, she finds her love and inspiration for photography again, and it starts to save her from the world she is currently stuck in. By the films end, Ella has lifted her camera, not to hold onto the past but to honour it by seeing it anew.

“FOCUS” is a poetic meditation on grief and rediscovery; it is a story for students and young creatives who may have lost their spark through life’s struggles. The main purpose of *FOCUS* is to remind them that healing is not about forgetting or moving on; it is about learning to see the world, and themselves through the eyes of people that inspired them to be happy (Library, 2025).

Goals

This section defines the creative and technical objectives of the short film “*FOCUS – Learning to See Again*”. It outlines the purpose, scope, and story structure, providing a foundation for the production process.

What is the purpose of the title

The purpose of the title for “*FOCUS*”, is to explore the emotional journey of healing and rediscovery through a lens of storytelling. The film uses cinematography (Boyd, 2024), lighting (Provost, 2025) and colours to represent Ella’s emotional state of mind – moving on from grief (Library, 2025). The title “*FOCUS*” symbolises both the act of focusing a camera and the metaphorical process of regaining emotional clarity. The narrative demonstrates how art, memory and perspective can help those to reconnect with a world that’s now different since their loss.

- **Emotional Storytelling Through Imagery** – This narrative relies on strong visual symbolism instead of heavy dialogue.
- **Cinematography** – Use of light, colour grading and framing to convey emotional progression.
- **Sound Design** – Minimal and atmospheric, using muted ambient sound and silence to reflect grief, gradually becoming clearer and warmer as Ella reconnects with her passion and the world around her.
- **Flashbacks** – Inclusion of old footage and home-video media to contrast through performance and visual cues.
- **Character Focus** – One protagonist (Ella), with emotional depth, portrayed through performance and visual cues
- **Visual Transformation** – Gradual shift from muted greys and monotone colours to soft warm tones as Ella starts to heal and progress through her grief.
- **Minimal Dialogue** – Mostly communication through gestures, silence, body language and facial expressions, rather than spoken words
- **Short Duration (9 minutes)** – Designed for short film festivals, student showcases and online platforms.

Theme:

- Primary Themes – Loss, Healing, Rediscovery, Creativity, Memories and Personal Growth

- Genre – Emotional Drama
- Background Story - Ella, once a passionate photographer, has lost someone who inspired her creativity. Struggling with grief, she isolates herself until rediscovering photographs of herself taken by Liam — sparking her journey back to connection and artistic expression.

What is the scope of the title

The scope of “FOCUS” encompasses both creative storytelling and technical film production elements. It will be an 8–10-minute short film combining narrative storytelling with visual symbolism.

Scope:

- Cinematic production using a Sony Alpha 6700 mirrorless camera. With professional composition and lighting.
- Colour grading to show emotional progression (vibrant → desaturated → warm).
- Inclusion of flashbacks through video texture manipulation.
- Soundtrack and ambient sound design to better promote tone and emotion.
- Editing and post-production using *DaVinci resolve* & *Adobe After Effects*.
- Visual effects such as soft-focus transitions, light leaks and film grain to better enhance the mood.

This project’s focus remains on emotional depth, creative cinematography and editing, thematic storytelling within a manageable short film format.

Script, Story & Theme

Format and Structure

The film follows a specific narrative with flashbacks interwoven throughout. Present day scenes depict Ella’s grief and struggle with losing Liam, while the flashbacks provide warmth and emotional context, gradually blending the two timelines into one as she starts to heal (Cid, 31).

Story Outline

Opening (Present Day)

- Early morning light streams through Ella’s window. She gets her camera bag ready, grabs a coffee and drives to college. The day feels calm, ordinary and has a gentle light.
- She hums along to the car radio; everything appears balanced and at peace.

Incident

- The song finishes and another appears on the radio.
- Ella's smile fades. The song stirs up memories of her and Liam listening to this song in a park, it's full of laughter, shared moments the one person who inspired her passion for photography.
- The colour palette of the film drastically shifts, the colour drains, from warm golden hues to grey and muted colours. Sound design narrows – the world around Ella becomes quieter, heavier.

Flashbacks

- Short, fragmented glimpses to Ella's past. Liam taking photos of Ella in their happy moments. The two full of light, laughter and fun. The two discussing what Ella's first camera should be.
- She begins to revisit those photographed places, (park, college, countryside) this time behind her lens.

Climax

- Standing in a familiar field at sunset, she lifts her camera – for the first time in a long time and takes one singular photo.
- This time, she's not capturing a memory of the past, but a moment in the present.

Ending

- Final montage, Ella looking at her new photos, sticking them in a photo album.
- The film closes with her standing by the window, camera in hand, light glowing on her face.
- Final quote – “Healing isn't about forgetting someone — it's learning to see the world they loved through your own eyes.”

Storytelling Style

- Visual Narrative: Emotion expressed through camera movement, composition, and colour rather than dialogue.
- Lighting Progression: Natural and bright at the beginning → dull and overcast during grief → warm and golden by the end.

- Sound Design: The emotional trigger song used in the car scene is a cover version recorded by a collaborator, chosen to create a more personal and intimate tone.

Symbolism:

- Camera – her connection to creativity and memory.
- Light – life and hope returning.
- Song – memory and emotional trigger.
- Colour – emotional tone and healing process.

User Experience

This section focuses on the audiences and user experience of the short film “FOCUS – Learning to See Again”. It focuses on who the film’s main target audience is, and how different people might connect with it. The short film uses visual storytelling to explore how grief, creativity, and memory shape the way people see the world.

Audience Definition

“FOCUS – Learning to See Again” is aimed mainly at students and young creatives who may be going through a difficult or emotional time – such as grief, burnout, or simply a creative block. The film’s slow pacing, use of imagery, and emotional tone are designed to make the audience reflect on their own experiences and feelings (Cognitive Theory On Films, 2014).

The story doesn’t just speak about loss – it also offers comfort by showing that healing comes from seeing things differently, not by forgetting. The film is intended for individuals who have ever lost their sense of purpose and is trying to reconnect with it again.

Target Audience Overview:

- Age Range: 18-30 years old.
- Gender: All
- Occupation: College students, young adults, emerging creatives such as photographers, artists, and designers.
- Interests: Storytelling, emotional or reflective films, photography, art, and creative expression.
- Psychographic Traits: Thoughtful, creative, emotionally aware, and open to interpretation and symbolism.

The audience should feel emotionally moved by Ella’s story and inspired by her journey. The film aims to leave viewers with a sense of hope — reminding them that creativity can be a way of healing and reconnecting with life.

Scenarios – typical user

Below are three audience personas who represent the different types of people likely to watch “FOCUS – Learning to See Again.” Each of them connects with the film in their own way and takes away a slightly different meaning.

Persona 1: “Amy” – The Creative Student

- Age: 21.
- Course: BA (Hons) in Marketing & Digital Media.
- Personality: Expressive, curious, and emotionally sensitive.
- Scenario: Amy has been struggling with creative burnout and finds it hard to feel inspired in her projects. She watches “FOCUS” during a short film screening at college.
- Experience: She connects deeply with Ella’s creative struggle and the way the film shows how art can bring someone back to life after loss. The use of light and colour reminds Amy why she started taking photos in the first place — to capture emotion, not perfection.
- Meaning Taken: Healing through creativity — learning to see beauty again even after pain.

Persona 2: “Liam” – The Quiet Viewer

- Age: 24.
- Occupation: Multimedia Designer, BA (Hons) in Design (Visual Communications) Graduate.
- Personality: Introverted, observant, empathetic.
- Scenario: Liam lost someone close to him a few years ago and hasn’t talked much about it. He comes across “FOCUS” online and decides to watch it out of curiosity.
- Experience: The scene where the song triggers Ella’s memories of Liam feels very real to him. The fading colour and silence perfectly capture the feeling of being pulled back into grief.
- Meaning Taken: Grief never fully disappears, but it can change — and through that change, we can rediscover ourselves.

Persona 3: “Sophie” – The Casual Viewer

- Age: 19.
- Course: BSc in TV and Media Production.
- Personality: Analytical, creative, enthusiastic about cinematography.

- Scenario: Sophie watches “FOCUS” as part of a short film showcase for class.
- Experience: She admires the cinematography and sound design — how the change in colour and tone mirrors Ella’s emotions. Even though she hasn’t experienced deep loss, she connects with the film’s message about personal growth and emotional awareness.
- Meaning Taken: Art can tell powerful stories without words — and emotion can be expressed visually through light, tone, and composition.

The overall experience of “FOCUS – Learning to See Again” is designed to be emotional, immersive, and relatable. It’s not just a story about grief — it’s about perspective, growth, and rediscovery.

By using minimal dialogue, soft lighting, and subtle symbolism, the film allows viewers to interpret the story in their own way. Whether they relate through loss, creativity, or personal reflection, each viewer should leave with a sense of calm and understanding that healing takes time, and that beauty can still be found in everyday moments.

Feasibility Study

A feasibility study was conducted to evaluate whether the short film “*FOCUS – Learning to See Again*” could be successfully completed within the constraints of time, available resources, and technical capability. The purpose of this analysis was to determine the practicality of the project within a student production context.

The study applied the TELOS framework, assessing five key areas: technological, economic, legal, operational, and schedule feasibility.

Before the Execution of the Project

Technological Feasibility

The project was expected to be achievable using equipment and software readily available through personal resources and college provision. The required tools were accessible through student licences or existing ownership, eliminating the need for specialist or high-cost equipment.

Equipment:

- Sony Alpha 6700 camera
- Tripod for stabilisation
- External microphone for audio capture
- Portable LED lighting or natural light sources
- Asus ZenBook laptop for editing and post-production

Software:

- DaVinci Resolve for editing and colour grading
- Adobe After Effects for visual effects and titles
- StoryTribe for storyboarding
- ShotGrid for production management
- Google Drive and OneDrive for file backup

Based on these resources, the project was considered technically feasible, with all required tools available to support both production and post-production processes.

Economic Feasibility

The project was expected to operate within a minimal budget, as most equipment and software were accessible without additional cost. Anticipated expenses were limited to minor production requirements.

Estimated Costs:

- Transport to filming locations: approximately €2.25
- Props and small set elements: €18–€35
- Storage (SD cards or backup media): €12–€25
- Optional soundtrack licensing: €0–€12

The projected total cost remained below €75, indicating that the project was financially manageable without the need for external funding.

Legal Feasibility

The production was expected to comply with standard legal and ethical guidelines for student filmmaking. All media used in the project was planned to be original or royalty-free to avoid copyright infringement.

A cover version of a song, performed by a collaborator, was to be included with explicit permission for educational use. Filming in public spaces was expected to be conducted responsibly, with consideration given to consent, privacy, and local regulations.

No significant legal constraints were anticipated.

Operational Feasibility

From an operational perspective, the project was designed to be manageable within a small-scale production structure. The use of a limited cast, minimal locations, and a simplified narrative approach reduced logistical complexity.

Filming was planned to take place in accessible environments, including domestic interiors, a vehicle, a college campus, and outdoor public spaces. This approach supported a practical and efficient production process.

Schedule Feasibility

The project was planned to be completed within the academic semester. A structured timeline was developed to allocate sufficient time to each stage of production.

Stage	Timeframe	Tasks
Pre-Production	18th Jan – 24th Jan 2026	Scriptwriting, planning, location scouting
Production	27th Jan – 14th Feb 2026	Filming and audio capture
Reshoots	17th Feb – 21st Feb 2026	Additional footage and corrections
Post-Production	24th Feb – 13th Mar 2026	Editing, colour grading, sound
Finalisation	23rd Mar – 3rd Apr 2026	Review, export, submission

The schedule was considered realistic, with buffer periods included to accommodate potential delays.

Feasibility Summary (Pre-Production)

The initial assessment indicated that the project was achievable within the available technical, financial, and operational constraints. The combination of accessible resources, low production costs, and a structured timeline supported the viability of the project within a student production environment.

After the Execution of the Project

Technological Feasibility

Following the completion of production and post-production, the technological approach proved to be effective. The equipment and software identified during the planning stage were sufficient to achieve the intended visual and technical standard.

The Sony Alpha 6700 performed reliably, particularly in natural lighting conditions. Its manual controls supported the intended visual contrast between muted present-day scenes and warmer flashbacks. The tripod contributed to consistent framing, aligning with the film's controlled visual style.

DaVinci Resolve enabled precise colour grading, allowing the planned tonal progression to be successfully implemented. Adobe After Effects supported the integration of subtle visual effects, enhancing the atmosphere without disrupting narrative clarity.

The Asus ZenBook laptop handled the editing workflow effectively, although higher-resolution footage increased rendering times. This limitation was addressed through the use of proxy files, maintaining workflow efficiency.

Cloud storage solutions, including Google Drive and OneDrive, ensured secure file management and reduced the risk of data loss.

The technological assumptions made during the planning phase were validated through practical application.

Economic Feasibility

The final cost of production remained within the projected budget. The use of existing equipment and software significantly reduced expenses, while minor costs were consistent with initial estimates.

Actual Costs:

- Transport: approximately €5
- Props: approximately €20
- Storage and backup: approximately €15

The total cost remained under €50, which was lower than the initial projection. This confirmed that the project was financially sustainable without external support.

Operational Feasibility

The production process was manageable within the planned structure. The decision to limit locations and maintain a small production scale contributed to efficient organisation and execution.

Filming in accessible locations reduced logistical complexity, while a small team allowed for flexibility in scheduling and decision-making. Adjustments to scenes could be made efficiently in response to environmental conditions or creative considerations.

The use of an iterative workflow supported ongoing refinement. Regular review of footage during production allowed issues to be identified and resolved before progressing to later stages.

Operational planning aligned effectively with the practical demands of the project.

Schedule Feasibility

The project was completed within the planned timeframe. The structured schedule supported consistent progress across all stages of production.

Pre-production was completed within the allocated period, enabling a clear transition into filming. Production largely followed the original timeline, with minor adjustments made due to weather and lighting conditions.

Post-production required additional time for colour grading and sound refinement. However, the inclusion of buffer periods allowed these adjustments to be accommodated without impacting the final submission date.

The timeline proved sufficiently flexible to support both planned work and necessary refinements.

Feasibility Summary (Post-Production)

The feasibility study accurately reflected the practical requirements of the project. The initial predictions regarding technology, cost, workflow, and scheduling were supported by the final outcome.

The project was completed within the identified constraints, with no significant deviations from the original feasibility assessment.

Methodology

This section outlines the creative and technical approach used in the development and production of the short film *“FOCUS – Learning to See Again.”* The methodology adopted combined elements of traditional film production with a reverse-engineering approach, allowing for both structured planning and iterative creative refinement.

This hybrid methodology was selected to balance the need for organisation with the flexibility required for an emotionally driven, visually focused project. While conventional filmmaking typically follows a linear progression from pre-production to post-production, this project required ongoing evaluation and adjustment, particularly in relation to visual tone, pacing, and emotional impact.

The Problem from a Process Viewpoint

From a process perspective, *“FOCUS”* presented a number of creative and technical challenges that influenced the choice of methodology. The film’s central themes—grief, healing, and rediscovery—were communicated primarily through visual storytelling techniques rather than dialogue.

This created a dependency on elements such as cinematography, lighting, colour grading, and sound design to convey meaning. As a result, many creative decisions could not be fully finalised during pre-production and instead required testing and refinement throughout the production process.

A strictly linear production model was therefore unsuitable, as it limited the ability to revisit and improve earlier decisions based on practical outcomes observed during filming and editing.

Key Problem Characteristics

- **Emotion-led visual storytelling:** The film relied on visual techniques rather than dialogue, requiring multiple iterations to achieve the intended emotional tone.
- **Minimal dialogue:** Narrative clarity depended entirely on imagery and sound, increasing the importance of experimentation and refinement.
- **Small-scale production:** Working with a limited cast and resources required a process that was adaptable while remaining manageable.

These characteristics necessitated a flexible methodology that could respond to creative challenges as they emerged, rather than enforcing a rigid sequence of development stages.

Assessment of Chosen Methodology

The methodology implemented for this project was a hybrid approach, combining the structured stages of traditional film production with elements of reverse engineering. This approach maintained the standard phases of pre-production, production, and post-production, while allowing for feedback loops between stages.

Traditional film production provided a clear organisational framework, ensuring that key planning materials such as the script, storyboard, animatic, and shot list guided the overall direction of the project. This structure was essential in maintaining consistency and ensuring that production remained aligned with the intended narrative.

However, the integration of reverse engineering allowed creative and technical decisions to be revisited and refined throughout the process. For example, initial footage reviews informed adjustments to lighting, composition, and pacing, which were then incorporated into subsequent filming and editing stages.

This iterative cycle of testing, evaluation, and refinement allowed the project to evolve beyond its initial plan, resulting in a more cohesive and emotionally effective final outcome.

Justification for the Methodology

The hybrid methodology was appropriate for this project due to its ability to support both creative exploration and structured production management.

- **Support for iterative creativity:** Reverse engineering enabled experimentation with visual and auditory elements, allowing creative decisions to be refined based on practical results rather than fixed assumptions.
- **Maintenance of professional workflow:** The structured stages of traditional filmmaking ensured that the project remained organised and within the required timeframe.
- **Adaptability:** The methodology allowed for adjustments in response to challenges such as lighting inconsistencies, environmental conditions, and pacing issues identified during editing.

In comparison to alternative approaches, such as a fully linear (Waterfall-style) production model, this hybrid method provided greater flexibility without compromising organisational control. A purely linear approach would have restricted the ability to revisit earlier decisions, while a fully iterative model may have lacked the structure required to meet project deadlines.

Evaluation of Methodology Effectiveness

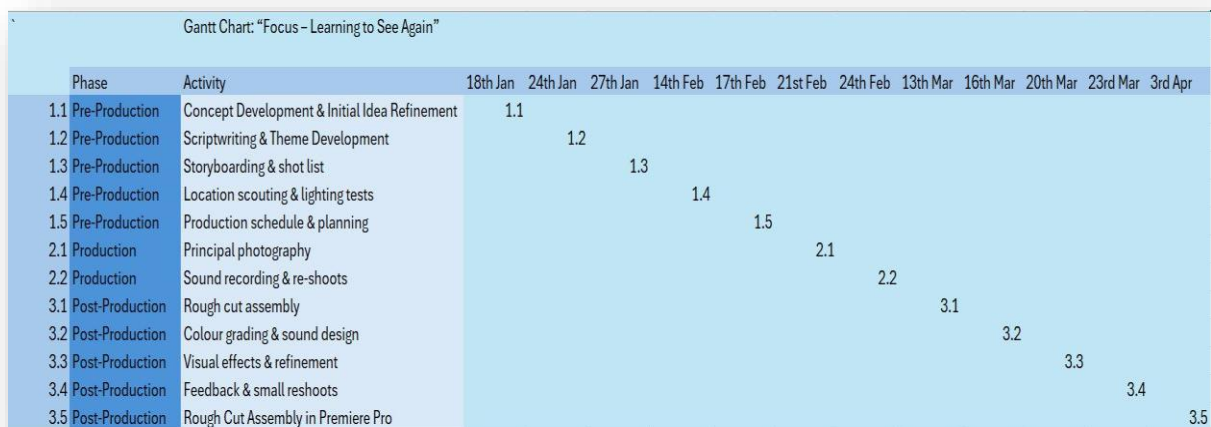
The methodology proved effective in supporting both the creative and technical development of the film. The structured elements ensured that the project progressed in a clear and organised manner, while the iterative components allowed for continuous improvement throughout production.

The ability to review and refine footage during filming reduced the risk of major issues emerging during post-production. Similarly, the flexibility to revisit earlier decisions contributed to a more consistent visual style and stronger emotional impact.

However, the iterative nature of the methodology also introduced challenges, particularly in relation to time management. Repeated refinement of visual and technical elements extended the duration of the post-production phase, requiring careful scheduling to ensure that deadlines were met.

Despite this limitation, the hybrid approach provided a balanced framework that supported both creativity and control. It allowed the project to adapt to practical challenges while maintaining alignment with its original vision.

Process Outline



The film-making process followed the three traditional stages of production while incorporating elements of reverse engineering where creative or technical adjustments were required.

Pre-Production (18th January – 24th January 2026)

The pre-production phase laid the groundwork for the short film. During this stage, the concept was fully developed and the visual direction clearly established.

- **Script Development:** The short film script was finalised, with a strong focus on emotional structure, symbolism, and visual storytelling.
- **Storyboarding:** A detailed storyboard and shot list were created to guide filming, highlighting planned shifts in colour, framing, and lighting to represent emotional change.
- **Location Scouting:** Locations were confirmed, including the home setting, car interior, and a college campus, chosen to reflect the protagonist's isolation and gradual reconnection with the world.
- **Camera and Lighting Tests:** Initial tests were carried out to explore the use of natural light, exposure, and colour temperature to support the film's emotional tone.
- **Scheduling:** A detailed production timetable was created to organise filming sessions, reshoots, and post-production work efficiently.

Production – Filming Phase (27th January – 14th February 2026)

This phase focused on capturing the required footage while incorporating aspects of reverse engineering.

- **Photography:** All planned scenes were filmed according to the storyboard. Adjustments were made where lighting conditions, framing, or camera movement produced more effective emotional results than initially planned.
- **Iterative Review:** Footage was reviewed regularly during the filming period. This allowed early identification of issues with tone, exposure, or pacing, leading to refinements or re-filming.
- **Sound Recording:** Ambient sound and environmental audio were captured on location to reinforce realism and atmosphere.

Reshoots and Additional Footage (17th February – 21st February 2026)

This phase focused on refining earlier production decisions through reflective review.

- **Reshoots:** Any missing or underperforming shots were re-filmed to better match the intended emotional and visual tone.
- **Visual Consistency:** Scenes were improved where lighting or colour progression did not fully support the emotional narrative.
- **Additional Audio:** Extra ambient audio and transitional sound elements were recorded where needed.

Post-Production – Editing and Colour (24th February – 13th March 2026)

Post-production involved both standard editing processes and reverse-engineered adjustments informed by earlier creative decisions.

- **Editing:** The footage was assembled into a full rough cut using Adobe Premiere Pro and DaVinci Resolve.
- **Colour Grading:** Gradual tonal shifts were applied, moving from muted greys to warmer hues to symbolise Ella's emotional healing.
- **Sound Design:** Ambient sound and music were synchronised and balanced to support mood and narrative flow.
- **Visual Refinement:** Subtle effects such as film grain, light leaks, and soft-focus elements were added in Adobe After Effects to strengthen atmosphere.

Feedback and Refinement (16th March – 20th March 2026)

- **Peer and Tutor Feedback:** Feedback was gathered on the rough cut to identify areas for improvement in pacing, emotional clarity, and visual consistency.
- **Reverse Engineering Review:** The film was reviewed as a near-complete project, allowing earlier creative choices to be reassessed and refined.
- **Final Adjustments:** Edits were made to timing, colour balance, and sound design to improve cohesion and emotional flow.

Finalisation and Submission (23rd March – 3rd April 2026)

The final stage consolidated all work into the completed project.

- **Quality Review:** The film was checked for consistency in pacing, transitions, colour grading, and audio balance.
- **Final Rendering:** The completed short film was exported in the required HD formats for submission and presentation.
- **Documentation:** All supporting materials, including this report, storyboards, and the animatic, were finalised and organised.

The hybrid methodology used for “*FOCUS*” successfully combined the structured workflow of traditional film production with the reflective adaptability of reverse engineering.

Risk Management

Risk management is an important part in the short film project “*FOCUS*” as it makes sure that potential challenges are identified early and managed well in advance. This section outlines the main risks, their possible impact, and the strategies in place to minimise or prevent them during production.

Identified Risks and Management Strategies:

- **Equipment Failure** - There is a medium likelihood that the camera, SD card, or laptop could malfunction or become damaged, which would have a high impact on the production due to the potential loss of footage or editing delays. Equipment will be checked and tested before filming, and college equipment will be borrowed if personal gear fails.
- **Weather Conditions** - As several scenes take place outdoors, poor weather such as rain, wind, or dull lighting could affect filming. The likelihood of this happening is high, and the impact would be medium, as delays or inconsistency in lighting could disrupt the project’s visual tone. To stop this from happening, weather forecasts will be checked often, and the filming schedule will remain flexible.
- **Time Management** - Balancing filming, editing, and coursework deadlines presents a high likelihood of time pressure, which could moderately affect the quality of production. This risk will be reduced by following a structured schedule with weekly goals, prioritising key scenes early in the shoot, and leaving additional buffer time for reshoots and post-production.
- **Illness** - Illness is another potential risk that could affect both the cast and crew during the production period. The likelihood is medium, and the impact could be high if the illness prevents key team members from participating in filming or post-production. To minimise this risk, a contingency plan will be in place to reschedule shoots if necessary. All team members will be encouraged to communicate early about any health concerns, and solo or small-scale reshoots will be prioritised if larger shoots need to be postponed.
- **Data Loss** - Although the likelihood of data loss is low, the impact would be high, as it could result in the loss of irreplaceable footage or edits. This risk will be managed by keeping multiple backups on external hard drives and cloud storage, enabling autosave functions in editing software, and storing duplicate copies of key files and final exports.
- **Creative or Technical Difficulties** - There is a medium likelihood that creative or technical challenges could arise, particularly due to inexperience with new

software such as DaVinci Resolve. The impact of this would be medium, as it could affect the overall polish and consistency of the film. To make sure this doesn't happen, test edits and practice colour grading sessions will be done before final production.

The overall risk level of the project is considered low to moderate. The main risks involve time management and technical reliability, both of which can be effectively controlled through careful organisation, regular backups, and proactive scheduling. By maintaining flexibility and adhering to proper production practices, "*FOCUS*" is well-positioned to be completed successfully within the project's timeframe and creative vision.

Tools and Technologies

The production of *“FOCUS – Learning to See Again”* utilised a range of hardware that supported both the visual and technical requirements of the film. Each piece of equipment was selected based on accessibility, reliability, and its ability to achieve a cinematic standard within a student production.

Hardware

The **Sony Alpha 6700 mirrorless camera** was used as the primary filming device. It provided high-resolution image quality and strong low-light performance, which was particularly important for scenes relying on natural lighting. The camera’s manual controls over focus, aperture, and exposure allowed for precise adjustments, supporting the film’s emphasis on visual storytelling and tonal variation.

A **tripod** was used to maintain stability during filming. This was essential for achieving clean, static shots that aligned with the film’s calm and reflective tone. The use of stable framing contributed to visual consistency and reduced the need for corrective stabilisation in post-production.

Post-production work was completed on an **Asus ZenBook laptop**, which provided sufficient processing power for editing, colour grading, and rendering. While the system handled most tasks effectively, higher-resolution footage resulted in longer rendering times. This was managed through the use of proxy files during editing, allowing for a smoother workflow without compromising final output quality.

Software

The production process also relied on a range of software tools that supported editing, visual effects, planning, and project management. These tools enabled an efficient workflow while maintaining a professional standard of production.

DaVinci Resolve was used as the primary software for video editing and colour grading. It allowed precise control over the film’s visual tone, which was essential in representing the protagonist’s emotional progression. The software enabled a gradual transition from desaturated grey tones to warmer hues, reinforcing the narrative themes of healing and rediscovery. Its integrated workflow improved efficiency by combining editing and grading within a single platform.

Adobe After Effects was used to create subtle visual enhancements, including light leaks, soft-focus transitions, and title elements. These effects contributed to the overall atmosphere of the film and supported the emotional tone without distracting from the

narrative. The software allowed for greater stylistic control, particularly in enhancing flashback sequences and transitions.

ShotGrid was used as a production management and tracking tool throughout the project. A dedicated project workspace was created to organise tasks, monitor progress, and manage assets across all stages of production. The platform was particularly valuable during post-production, where multiple versions of each shot were uploaded and tracked.

ShotGrid Login: 20102339@mail.wit.ie

Password: Focus20102339!

Raw footage was organised by scene and take, while successive edits were saved as new versions. This version control system allowed for clear comparison between edits and supported an iterative workflow, where changes could be reviewed and refined over time. The structured organisation reduced confusion when managing multiple files and ensured that all assets remained accessible throughout the editing process.

In addition, the use of ShotGrid introduced a workflow aligned with industry practices, particularly in relation to asset management and production tracking. This contributed to a more organised and professional approach to project development.

Google Drive and **OneDrive** were used for cloud storage and file backup. These platforms ensured that all project files, including raw footage, project files, and final exports, were securely stored and accessible across devices. Multiple backups were maintained to minimise the risk of data loss and to support continuity in the event of technical issues.

StoryTribe was used during pre-production to create digital storyboards. This allowed scenes to be visually planned in advance, supporting shot composition, pacing, and narrative structure. The use of storyboarding software provided a clear visual reference during filming and contributed to a more efficient production process.

Canva was used to create visual design elements supporting the presentation and promotion of the project. This included the development of the film's thumbnail. Canva also provided access to typography, colour grading tools, and layout options, enabling consistency in visual branding. Its accessibility and ease of use made it a practical tool for producing supporting materials alongside the main film production.

Technical Pipeline and Production Workflow

The production of “FOCUS – Learning to See Again” followed a structured technical workflow, where each stage of the filmmaking process contributed to the development of the final outcome. Although the project is a creative short film rather than a traditional software system, it still required a clearly defined pipeline to ensure consistency, efficiency, and quality throughout production and post-production.

The workflow can be understood as a sequence of stages: capture, ingestion, organisation, editing, colour grading, sound design, and final output.

Capture Stage

The first stage of the process involved capturing raw video and audio using the Sony Alpha 6700 camera. Footage was recorded in high resolution to preserve detail and allow flexibility during post-production, particularly in colour grading. Manual camera settings such as exposure, focus, and white balance were adjusted carefully to maintain visual consistency across scenes and to support the intended emotional tone of the film.

Audio was captured using both in-camera recording and external microphones where necessary. This provided multiple audio sources, allowing for greater control during editing and sound design.

Ingestion and Organisation

After filming, all footage was transferred from SD cards to the editing workstation. A structured file management system was used to organise the project assets efficiently. Footage was sorted by scene and take, while separate folders were created for audio, project files, and exported versions.

Cloud storage platforms, including Google Drive and OneDrive, were used to create backup copies of all files. This ensured that data was secure and could be accessed across different devices, reducing the risk of data loss.

Editing Workflow

The editing process was carried out using DaVinci Resolve, following a non-linear editing workflow. This allowed footage to be arranged, adjusted, and refined without affecting the original media files.

The process began with assembling a rough cut based on the storyboard. This was followed by multiple iterations where pacing, transitions, and shot selection were refined to better reflect the emotional progression of the narrative. The non-linear approach allowed for flexibility, making it possible to revisit and improve earlier edits as the film developed.

Proxy Workflow

Due to the high resolution of the footage, playback performance during editing was initially limited. To address this, a proxy workflow was implemented. Lower-resolution versions of the clips were generated, allowing for smoother playback and more efficient editing.

These proxy files remained linked to the original footage, ensuring that the final export retained full visual quality while maintaining an efficient workflow during the editing process.

Colour Grading

Colour grading was a key technical and creative stage within the workflow. Using DaVinci Resolve, adjustments were made to saturation, contrast, temperature, and exposure to reflect Ella's emotional journey.

The film transitions from desaturated, cool tones in the earlier scenes to warmer tones towards the end. This gradual shift was carefully controlled to ensure consistency across shots while reinforcing the narrative themes of grief and healing.

Sound Design

Sound design was developed alongside the visual edit to support the overall atmosphere of the film. Ambient audio, music, and silence were used to reflect emotional tone and pacing.

Audio levels were balanced, and transitions such as fades were applied to create a smooth listening experience. The inclusion of the emotional trigger song played an important role in linking present-day scenes with flashbacks, enhancing the audience's connection to the narrative.

Visual Enhancements

Additional visual elements were created using Adobe After Effects and integrated into the final edit. These included subtle effects such as light leaks, soft-focus transitions, and film grain. These elements were used sparingly to enhance the mood of the film without distracting from the narrative.

Final Output

The final stage of the workflow involved rendering the completed film in high-definition format. Before export, the project was reviewed to ensure consistency in colour, audio levels, and overall pacing.

The completed film was then prepared for online distribution, allowing it to be shared for viewing, feedback, and assessment.

Project Reflection

This section critically evaluates the development and outcome of the short film “*FOCUS – Learning to See Again*,” reflecting on both the creative and technical processes undertaken throughout the project lifecycle.

Overall Outcome

The project was completed within the planned timeframe and achieved its primary creative and technical objectives. The final film effectively communicated its central themes of loss, healing, and rediscovery through a visually driven narrative.

Rather than relying on dialogue, the film demonstrated how cinematography, colour grading, and sound design could function as primary storytelling mechanisms. This approach strengthened audience engagement by encouraging interpretation, allowing meaning to emerge through visual and tonal progression rather than explicit explanation.

A significant strength of the outcome was the controlled use of colour as an emotional device. The gradual transition from desaturated tones to warmer hues provided a clear visual representation of the protagonist’s internal development. This technique reinforced narrative coherence while supporting the intended emotional impact.

Strengths of the Project

One of the most effective aspects of the project was the strength of pre-production planning. The development of a detailed script, storyboard, and shot list established a clear visual direction, which contributed to consistency throughout production. This demonstrated the importance of structured preparation in projects that rely heavily on visual storytelling rather than dialogue.

Cinematography also represented a key strength. The use of natural lighting, combined with controlled framing and composition, created a cohesive visual style that aligned with the film’s emotional tone. The decision to adopt a minimalist dialogue approach proved effective, as it required the audience to actively engage with the imagery and interpret the narrative independently.

Post-production played a central role in shaping the final outcome. The use of DaVinci Resolve enabled precise control over colour grading, which became integral to the storytelling process rather than a purely technical adjustment. Subtle visual effects and carefully balanced sound design further enhanced the atmosphere, demonstrating how post-production can contribute directly to narrative meaning.

Challenges and Limitations

Despite the success of the project, several challenges emerged throughout production. Time management was a significant issue, particularly during post-production. Editing and colour grading required more time than initially anticipated due to the iterative process involved in achieving visual consistency. This highlighted the difficulty of accurately estimating time requirements in creative workflows, where outcomes often depend on experimentation and refinement.

Environmental factors also presented challenges. Variations in weather conditions affected lighting consistency across outdoor scenes, resulting in continuity issues that required additional reshoots and corrective adjustments during editing. This emphasised the limitations of relying on natural lighting and the importance of contingency planning when working in uncontrolled environments.

The project was further constrained by the limitations typical of student productions, including restricted access to advanced equipment and a small production scale. While these constraints encouraged problem-solving and adaptability, they also limited the ability to explore more complex camera movement and technical setups.

Areas for Improvement

If the project were to be developed further, several improvements could be made. Allocating additional time to post-production would allow for more refined colour grading and sound design, particularly in achieving greater consistency across scenes.

Expanding the feedback process to include a wider audience at earlier stages would also strengthen the final outcome. Early audience testing could provide more detailed insights into pacing, narrative clarity, and emotional engagement, allowing for more targeted revisions.

From a technical perspective, access to additional equipment, such as stabilisation tools and higher-quality audio recording devices, would improve production quality and enable more ambitious visual execution.

Key Learning Outcomes

The project provided valuable insight into both the creative and technical demands of short film production. It reinforced the importance of thorough pre-production planning, particularly in projects that rely on visual communication rather than dialogue.

The use of a hybrid methodology proved effective in supporting iterative development. Allowing post-production experimentation to inform earlier creative decisions contributed to a more refined and cohesive final outcome.

The project also supported the development of practical skills in cinematography, editing, and project management. In addition, it deepened an understanding of how visual techniques can be used to communicate complex emotional narratives without reliance on dialogue. These insights will inform future work, particularly in the application of visual storytelling as a primary narrative approach.

User Feedback and Testing

This section evaluates the audience response to “*FOCUS – Learning to See Again*” through informal user testing and feedback. The purpose of this testing was to assess how effectively the film communicated its themes, emotional tone, and visual storytelling.

Testing Process

The short film was shown to a small group of viewers, including classmates, peers from creative courses, and individuals within the target audience range of 18–30. These viewers were selected as they represented the intended audience of students and young creatives.

Feedback was gathered through informal discussions after viewing, as well as brief written responses. Viewers were asked to comment on the emotional impact of the film, clarity of the narrative, pacing, and the effectiveness of visual elements such as colour and sound.

Positive Feedback

The majority of the feedback received was highly positive. Many viewers responded greatly to the emotional tone of the film, particularly the use of colour grading to represent Ella’s journey through grief and healing.

The minimal use of dialogue was also highlighted as a strength. Viewers noted that the reliance on visual storytelling made the film more immersive and allowed for personal interpretation. Several viewers commented that this approach made the narrative feel more realistic and emotionally impactful.

Constructive Feedback

While the overall response was positive, some constructive feedback was also identified. A small number of viewers felt that certain sections of the film, particularly in the early stages, were slightly slow in pacing. Although this was intentional to reflect Ella’s emotional state, it suggested that minor adjustments to timing could improve engagement.

Some viewers also noted that the narrative required careful attention to fully understand, due to the lack of dialogue. While this aligned with the film’s visual storytelling approach, it highlighted the importance of ensuring that key story elements were communicated as clearly as possible through imagery and editing.

In terms of sound design, a few viewers suggested that certain ambient sounds could be enhanced to further strengthen immersion and emotional impact.

Changes Made Based on Feedback

Based on the feedback received, minor adjustments were made during the final stages of post-production. These included refining the pacing of certain scenes to improve flow, slightly enhancing audio levels for ambient sound, and ensuring smoother transitions between key emotional moments.

Although no major structural changes were required, the feedback process helped to improve the overall polish and clarity of the final film.

Editing Process (Post-Production)

The editing process for “*FOCUS – Learning to See Again*” was completed using DaVinci Resolve, which was used for both video editing and colour grading. The workflow followed an iterative approach, where footage was progressively refined in order to achieve the intended emotional tone and visual consistency of the film.

Project Assembly and Initial Structure

The editing process began with importing and organising all footage into a structured timeline based on the storyboard. This ensured that the narrative flow was clearly established from the outset.

An introductory sequence was created, beginning with a title card designed in Canva. This was incorporated at the start of the film to establish tone and context. A **dip-to-colour dissolve transition** was applied between the title card and Scene 1, creating a smooth visual entry into the narrative.

A DSLR-style visual effect was also applied to selected shots to enhance the cinematic aesthetic and reinforce the theme of memory and perspective throughout the film.

Scene 1 – Colour Grading and Emotional Tone

Scene 1 was graded to establish the emotional baseline of the film, representing Ella’s detached and muted emotional state.

Adjustments included:

- Gamma increased to **0.05** to lift midtones slightly while maintaining a subdued look
- Gain increased to **1.25** to enhance overall exposure
- Offset adjusted to **+25.00** to subtly brighten the image
- Saturation reduced to **30.00** to create a desaturated, lifeless palette
- Temperature shifted to **-90.0** to introduce a colder blue tone
- Contrast adjusted to **0.980** to soften overall visual intensity

These adjustments were applied to reinforce the theme of emotional numbness and isolation at the beginning of the narrative.

Car Scene – Emotional Trigger Sequence

The car sequence required a more controlled and gradual shift in tone to reflect the emotional trigger caused by the music.

Colour grading adjustments included:

- Saturation reduced to **20.00** to further desaturate the environment
- Temperature shifted to **-50.00** to maintain a cold but slightly more natural tone compared to Scene 1

This subtle difference allowed for a visual transition between emotional states while maintaining continuity across scenes.

Bedroom Scene – Memory Card Discovery

In the bedroom scene where Ella discovered the memory card, the raw footage appeared warmer and more yellow than originally intended. This conflicted with the desired emotional tone, requiring corrective colour grading.

Adjustments included:

- Temperature reduced to **-270.00** to neutralise the yellow tones
- Colour boost reduced to **-10.00** to limit colour intensity
- Shadows increased to **25.00** to deepen contrast
- Saturation reduced to **25.00**

These changes restored visual consistency with the film's muted aesthetic and ensured the scene aligned with Ella's emotional state at that point in the narrative.

Visual Enhancements and Effects

Several technical adjustments and effects were applied to enhance visual quality and storytelling:

- A **stabilisation effect** was applied to the shot of the camera on the windowsill to improve smoothness and maintain visual focus
- A **DSLR-style effect** was used across selected scenes to reinforce the theme of captured memory and perspective

- At the end of the film, a **fade to black with complete audio removal** was applied to the final shot of Ella, creating a moment of silence and emotional closure

Final Scene – Symbolic Transition

In the final scene, when Ella takes a photograph, a **fade to white transition** was applied. This was designed to resemble the visual effect of a photograph being taken and developing.

This transition symbolised clarity, renewal, and emotional resolution, visually reinforcing the theme of healing and rediscovery.

Narrative Pacing and Final Structure

During editing, careful attention was given to pacing in order to reflect Ella's emotional journey. Longer static shots were retained in early scenes to emphasise stillness and detachment, while later sequences were paced more dynamically to reflect emotional reawakening.

Transitions and cuts were refined through multiple iterations to ensure that the visual flow of the film remained consistent with its narrative structure.

Export and Final Output

Once editing and grading were complete, the film was rendered in high-definition format using DaVinci Resolve's export settings. The final output was checked for consistency in colour, audio balance, and resolution prior to submission

Management of the Process

This section outlines how the development and production of “FOCUS – Learning to See Again” was planned, organised, and managed throughout the project lifecycle. Effective management ensured that all stages were completed within the given timeframe while maintaining a consistent creative vision.

Project Organisation

The project was structured around the three main stages of film production: pre-production, production, and post-production. Each phase included clearly defined tasks and deliverables, supporting a logical progression from concept to final output.

A detailed schedule was created at the beginning of the project, outlining weekly goals and deadlines. This acted as a guide throughout production and ensured steady progress across key tasks such as scriptwriting, storyboarding, filming, editing, and final review.

Task and Time Management

Task management was carried out using a combination of planning tools and personal organisation methods. ShotGrid was used to track progress, organise assets, and monitor completed and remaining tasks. A structured checklist approach ensured that all required elements were completed systematically, supported by regular progress reviews.

Time management was supported through a structured timeline, represented using a Gantt chart. This outlined all key stages from pre-production to submission, allowing for clear tracking of progress. While the schedule provided structure, flexibility was required to adapt to challenges such as weather conditions and the time-intensive nature of post-production. Buffer periods allowed for reshoots and additional refinement without impacting the overall timeline.

Workflow and Communication

As the project was primarily managed independently, maintaining an organised workflow was essential. Files were structured by production stage, including raw footage, edited sequences, audio files, and final exports, improving efficiency during editing.

Cloud storage, including Google Drive, was used to back up all project files, ensuring secure and accessible data management. Feedback from peers and tutors was gathered throughout the project, particularly during post-production, supporting continuous improvement.

Adaptability and Problem Management

Despite careful planning, challenges such as weather conditions and extended editing time required adjustments to the workflow. These issues were managed by adapting the schedule, prioritising key tasks, and using the reshoot phase effectively.

The hybrid methodology supported this adaptability, allowing creative decisions to be refined through testing and feedback. This ensured the project remained aligned with its intended vision while responding to practical challenges.

Version Control and Asset Management

Version control was implemented using ShotGrid, allowing structured organisation and tracking of project files. Each stage of the editing process was saved as a new version, enabling changes to be reviewed and refined over time.

Assets, including raw footage and edited sequences, were categorised within the project workspace, ensuring clarity when managing multiple versions. This approach reduced the risk of data loss and provided a clear record of the project's development, supporting an efficient and professional workflow.

Final Film / Demo

The final outcome of this project was the completed short film “*FOCUS – Learning to See Again*”. The film was produced in line with the original concept and successfully combined visual storytelling, sound design, and colour grading to communicate its central themes of loss, healing, and rediscovery.

The finished film had a duration of approximately 9 minutes and followed the planned narrative structure, including the integration of flashbacks, symbolic imagery, and minimal dialogue. The use of cinematography and post-production techniques allowed the emotional journey of the protagonist to be conveyed clearly, with particular emphasis on the transition from desaturated tones to warmer colours.

The final version of the film was exported in high-definition format and prepared for submission and presentation. Care was taken to ensure consistency in visual quality, audio levels, and overall pacing. The completed project met the technical and creative requirements outlined at the beginning of the production process.

The short film was made available for viewing via an online platform to allow for easy access and sharing. This also supported the user testing process, enabling feedback to be gathered from the intended audience.

Final Film Link:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2sVXEeanDTI>

Animatic YouTube Link:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JRNmx4OawLA&feature=youtu.be>

The final film successfully reflected the intended vision of the project and demonstrated the effective use of visual media to communicate emotion and narrative without relying heavily on dialogue.

The film was also supported by supplementary materials including storyboards, animatic, and trailer (see [Appendices](#))

Schedule

This schedule outlines the planned timeline for completing all stages of the short film “*FOCUS*” during Semester 2. The timeline is realistic for a student project and includes room for reshoots, editing revisions.

18th January – 24th January 2026

Pre-Production – Final Planning

- Final polish of script
 - Update storyboard and shot list
 - Confirm locations around SETU campus, home, and outdoor areas, such as the Car
 - Do camera and lighting tests to check exposure and tone
 - Prepare props, costumes, and equipment list
 - Create detailed shooting schedule
-

27th January – 14th February 2026

Production – Filming Phase

- Film all indoor scenes (bedroom, kitchen, laptop/album scenes)
 - Film car interior scenes and sound recordings for car radio
 - Begin shooting external scenes depending on weather
 - Collect ambient audio and b-roll shots
 - Review footage daily and plan reshoots where needed
-

17th February – 21st February 2026

Reshoots & Additional Footage

- Capture any missing shots
 - Improve scenes where lighting or colour tone didn't match the emotional progression
 - Record extra audio for ambience, transitions, and Foley if needed
-

24th February – 13th March 2026

Post-Production – Editing & Colour

- Assemble first full rough cut
 - Edit pacing, transitions, and visual rhythm
 - Begin colour grading (grey desaturation → warm tones)
 - Add flashback visual effects (soft-focus, grain, light leaks)
 - Sync audio and refine sound design around the key emotional moments
-

16th March – 20th March 2026

Feedback & Refinement

- Gather peer/tutor feedback
 - Adjust pacing and emotional beats
 - Re-grade scenes that feel inconsistent
 - Finalise sound mix and overall tone
-

23rd March – 3rd April 2026

Finalisation & Submission

- Final render of the film
 - Export in required formats
 - Complete supporting documentation (report, storyboard, evaluations)
 - Backup everything to cloud storage
 - Submit project
-

Future Work

While “FOCUS – Learning to See Again” successfully achieved its intended creative and technical objectives, there are several areas where the project could be further developed and improved in future iterations.

From a technical perspective, access to additional equipment would enhance overall production quality. The use of stabilisation tools such as a gimbal would allow for smoother camera movement, while higher-quality audio recording equipment would improve sound clarity and reduce the need for post-production correction. A more advanced lighting setup would also provide greater control over exposure and consistency, particularly in outdoor scenes where natural lighting conditions can vary.

In terms of post-production, allocating additional time to colour grading and sound design would allow for further refinement. While the current grading effectively communicates the emotional progression of the narrative, more detailed adjustments could improve consistency across all scenes. Similarly, expanding the sound design with additional ambient layers and subtle audio effects would strengthen immersion and emotional impact.

From a creative perspective, the narrative could be expanded to include additional scenes or further character development. This could provide deeper insight into Ella’s relationship with Liam, strengthening the emotional connection for the audience. Introducing more varied visual storytelling techniques or camera movement could also enhance engagement while maintaining the film’s reflective tone.

User testing could also be developed further by gathering feedback from a wider and more diverse audience. Conducting more structured evaluations, such as questionnaires or comparative testing, would provide more detailed insights into audience interpretation, pacing, and emotional response.

These potential improvements would build upon the existing foundation of the project, allowing “FOCUS – Learning to See Again” to be developed into a more technically refined and narratively rich production.

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Appendices

Script - FOCUS

- Tone: Quiet, warm, emotional, visual storytelling
- Dialogue: Minimal
- Main Character: Ella, early 20s, photographer
- Lost Friend: Liam, shown only in flashbacks and photos

SCENE 1 — ELLA’S BEDROOM (MORNING)

WIDE SHOT — A small, slightly cluttered bedroom washed in pale morning light.

The room feels lived-in but paused, like someone pressed a pause button months ago and never resumed.

DETAILS OF THE ROOM:

- The room is clean but no colour in anything, the grey walls wash the room.
- Her camera sits on the windowsill, lens cap on, a thin layer of dust over it.
- There is a pale and subtle light coming from the window, as Ella’s back is to the window it flushed her out making her appear dark.

CLOSE-UP — Ella sits on her bed, dressed in comfort clothes, her eyes are tired, unfocused.

She listens to a voice note on her phone from Liam

Liams voice: “One day your gonna look back at this and see how far you’ve come.”

She stands up and picks up her college bag.

The silence in the room feels heavy.

She moves around with mechanical slowness and goes towards the door to leave the room.

SCENE 2 — KITCHEN (CONTINUOUS)

WIDE SHOT — A small student flat kitchen.

Clean but quiet. A single mug left on the counter from last night.

The kettle hums.

CLOSE-UP — Ella stirring tea absentmindedly, staring at the swirling liquid.

OVER-THE-SHOULDER SHOT

- A note from Liam saying, “Keep looking for the light - Liam.”
- She stands by the fridge sipping her tea.

She grabs her bag and leaves.

SCENE 3 — CAR PARK / CAR INTERIOR

WIDE SHOT — Ella approaches her car in the muted morning light.

The world is still in natural colour here — soft, quiet, ordinary.

CLOSE-UP — Her hand unlocks the door.

She gets inside.

MID SHOT (INSIDE CAR) — Ella sits, hands resting on the steering wheel.

She exhales slowly.

Another day she’s barely present.

She turns the key.

SFX: The radio crackles to life... and then plays Liam’s song.

A familiar acoustic melody fills the car.

At the exact moment the first chord plays—

COLOUR TRANSITION MOMENT

A subtle but noticeable colour drain effect begins — not immediate desaturation, but a slow, creeping loss of warmth in the image.

CLOSE-UP — Ella’s eyes widen.

Her breath catches.

SLOW PUSH-IN — As she realises what song is playing.

COLOUR DRAINS FURTHER —

Skin tones cool.

The warm dashboard lights fade to a sterile white.

The vibrant reds of passing cars outside shift towards grey.

Only the radio display remains slightly warm — the last link to Liam.

FLASH CUTS — HOME VIDEO STYLE

Bright, warm colours — in stark contrast to the drained present.

Set in a living room, there's coloured lights, we can assume it's a holiday (Christmas).

Liam taking photo's Ella sitting a couch.

Ella and Liam laughing having fun as Liams snapping pictures of the memory.

The scene is quite as the triggering song plays in the background.

BACK TO PRESENT — ALMOST FULLY DESATURATED

POV SHOT — Dashboard, steering wheel, lifeless grey world through the windscreen.

EXTREME CLOSE-UP — A tear forms at the edge of Ella's eye.

MATCH CUT — To her hand gripping the face, to hide her tears.

The colour finally completes its drain:

Ella in muted greys and cold tones

Car interior nearly monochrome

The world outside washed out

But Liam's song remains warm in sound — the only warmth left.

Ella swallows hard, blinking back tears.

Song fades out before scene ends.

SCENE 4 — UNI CAMPUS (LATER)

WIDE SHOT — In front of a college building, students chatting, having fun out of frame but their voices can be heard.

Ella blends into the background, a ghost moving through colour.

She passes by the entrance building on her way to class.

CLASSROOM INTERIOR –

WIDE SHOT — A quiet college computer lab.

Students are already seated, focused, typing, editing — the soft clatter of keyboards

fills the room.

The space feels functional, but alive in a way Ella isn't.

Ella enters hesitantly, almost late.

Ella sits at the top of the classroom; she removes her coat and puts down her bag.

No one looks up. Everyone is immersed in their work.

OUTSIDE CLASSROOM - Ella passes by a door to a classroom, there is a poster that reads: "Photography Exhibit".

Ella pauses to read the poster, then continues walking down the hall to her class.

SUBTLE CONTRAST —

Their screens glow with colour — photos, projects, creativity in motion.

Ella moves through it in muted tones, disconnected.

INSERT SHOT — Her hands hover over the keyboard.

She starts typing.

She types.

Stops.

Deletes.

SCENE 5 — KITCHEN (EVENING)

Ella arrives home, similar to shot #5 when she was leaving, just reversed. Its darker now.

Time has passed and it's the evening.

Ella arrives through the door, turning on a dim light that fills the room. She walks through to head towards her bedroom, tired from the day.

ELLAS BEDROOM -

A mirror of Scene 1, but the light is now blue, colder.

Ella enters and drops her bag.

MID SHOT — She sits on the floor beside her bed.

A sigh.

A long silence.

She starts organising some boxes under her bed — old uni work, memories she's been ignoring.

CLOSE-UP — Her hand reaches into a box.

Pulls out an old memory card case.

She inaudibly gasps.

EXTREME CLOSE-UP — The memory card:

Labelled "To Ella, From Liam"

Her breath catches.

She takes a moment to exam the memory card and stops still to think "what could this be?"

She inserts the memory card into her laptop.

The screen lights up her face.

She begins to look at footage / pictures of herself on the screen, suddenly Ella shuts the laptop closed.

She pauses to think, then after a moment, she reopens the laptop

SCENE 6 — THE PHOTOS

WIDE SHOT — Ella sitting in the dimly lit room, laptop screen glowing.

She clicks on the folder.

Inside... dozens of photos.

Photos of her.

Photos she didn't know existed.

SLOW PUSH-IN — As she scrolls.

CLOSE-UP SERIES —

Ella laughing mid-conversation

Ella adjusting her camera during a golden hour shoot

Ella sitting under a tree reading

Pictures of Ella and Liams memory's

Ella looking determined, creative, alive

Every shot is filled with warmth, admiration — and love.

Her eyes fill.

Then—

She sees a video thumbnail.

SCENE 7 — VIDEO MESSAGE

She hesitates.

Clicks.

VIDEO PLAYBACK — HOME-VIDEO STYLE

Liam has a camera set on a tripod and is recording himself sitting in a chair speaking to the camera.

MEDIUM SHOT (VIDEO):

“Okay... if you’re watching this, I finally got you to take a day off.”

He laughs.

“You don’t see it yet... but you will. You always do. One day you’ll focus again.”

This line echoes in Ella’s mind.

The shot goes blurry for a moment, then focuses

Ella covers her mouth, tears silently falling.

The video ends.

Silence.

SCENE 8 — REIGNITION

CLOSE-UP — Ella looking at her dusty camera, the camera Liam had gifted her, on the windowsill.

She stands.

TRACKING SHOT — Following her as she walks slowly to her bed, she sits, admiring it.

Her hand gripping the camera again — hesitant... then firm.

She lifts it.

For the first time in months.

SCENE 9 — OUTSIDE (NEXT MORNING)

WIDE SHOT — Mid-day. The park is calm.

Ella steps outside with her camera around her neck.

The world is still slightly muted, reflecting the slow return of her emotional life.

MID SHOT — Ella lifts the camera to her eye.

The frame looks greyish at first — muted like before — but her fingers are steady now.

POV SHOT THROUGH CAMERA —

Ella focuses on a beam of sunlight breaking through tree branches.

CLICK. The shutter fires.

CLOSE-UP — The image on the camera screen.

Colour seeping back slowly:

Warm greens of the leaves

Golden light on the grass

Blue sky becoming vibrant again

The photo represents her renewed vision and the return of life and warmth, a visual echo of the healing process.

OVER-THE-SHOULDER SHOT — Ella smiles softly, slow but happy.

The sunlight glints off her camera lens, glinting like small sparks of life.

WIDE SHOT — She lowers the camera, looks around the park, fully present in the now-colourful world.

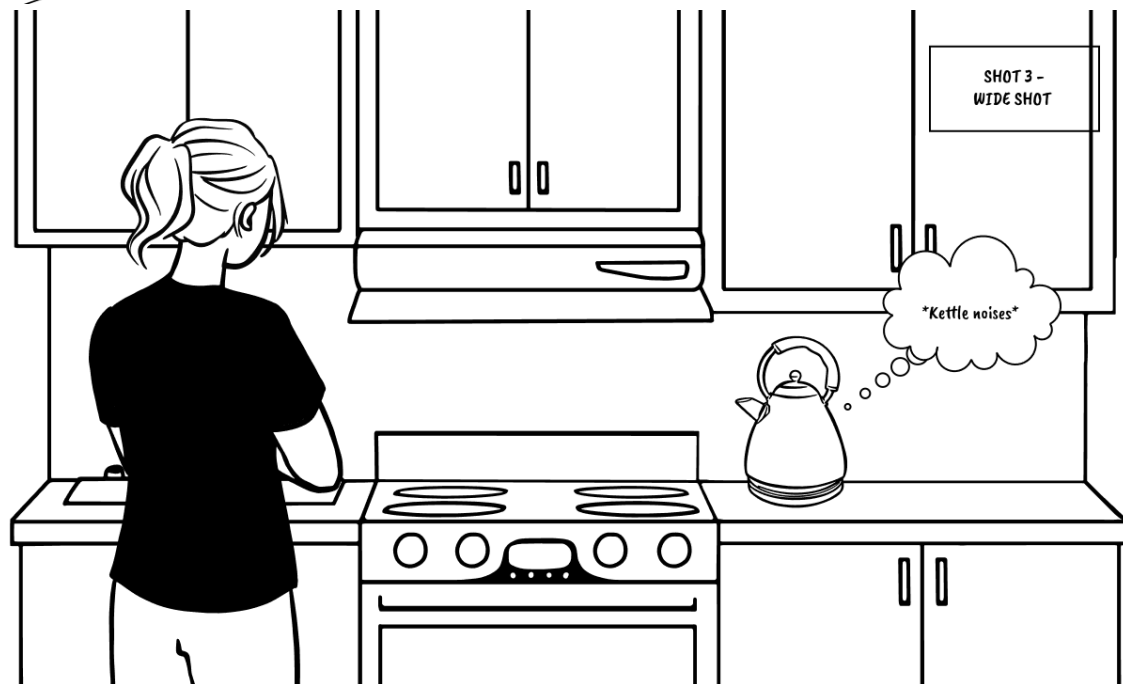
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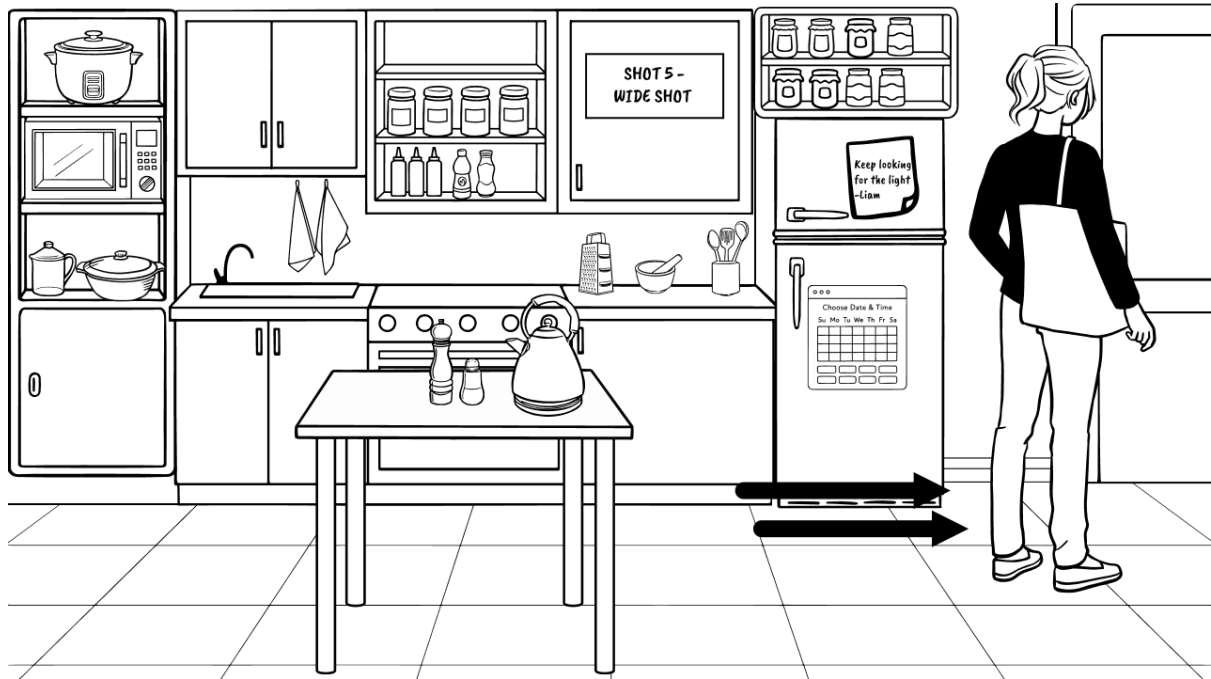
TITLE CARD:

“Healing isn’t about forgetting someone. It’s learning to see again.”

Storyboard including Camera Angles

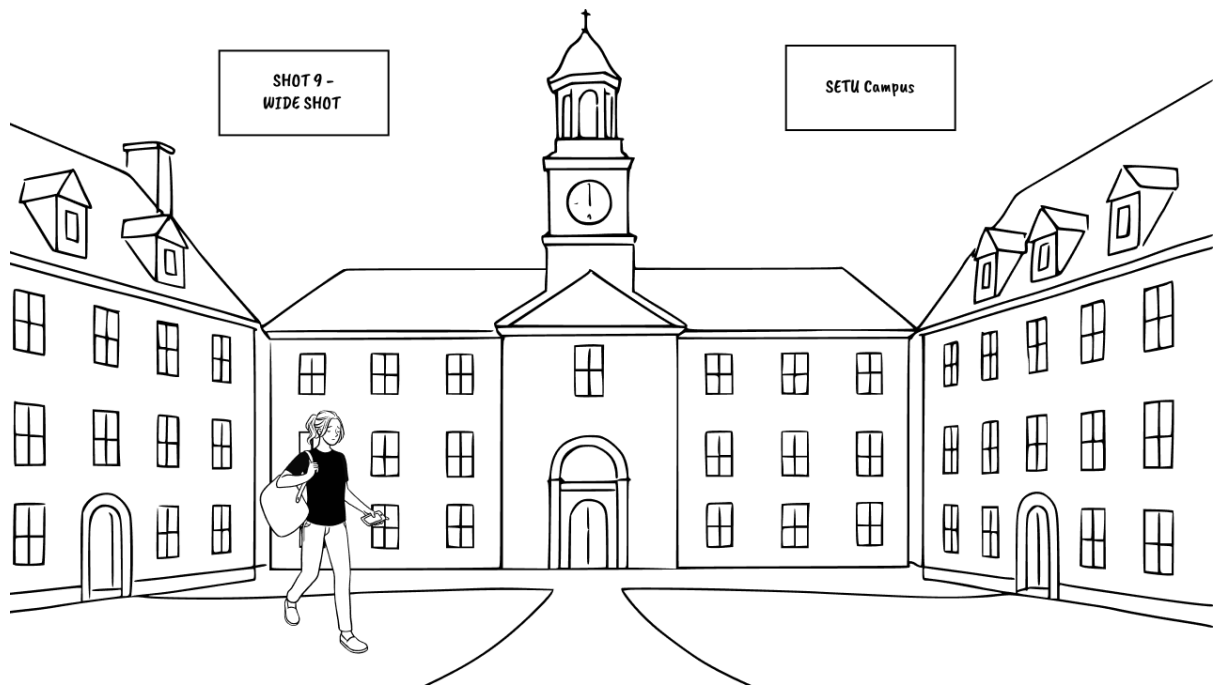




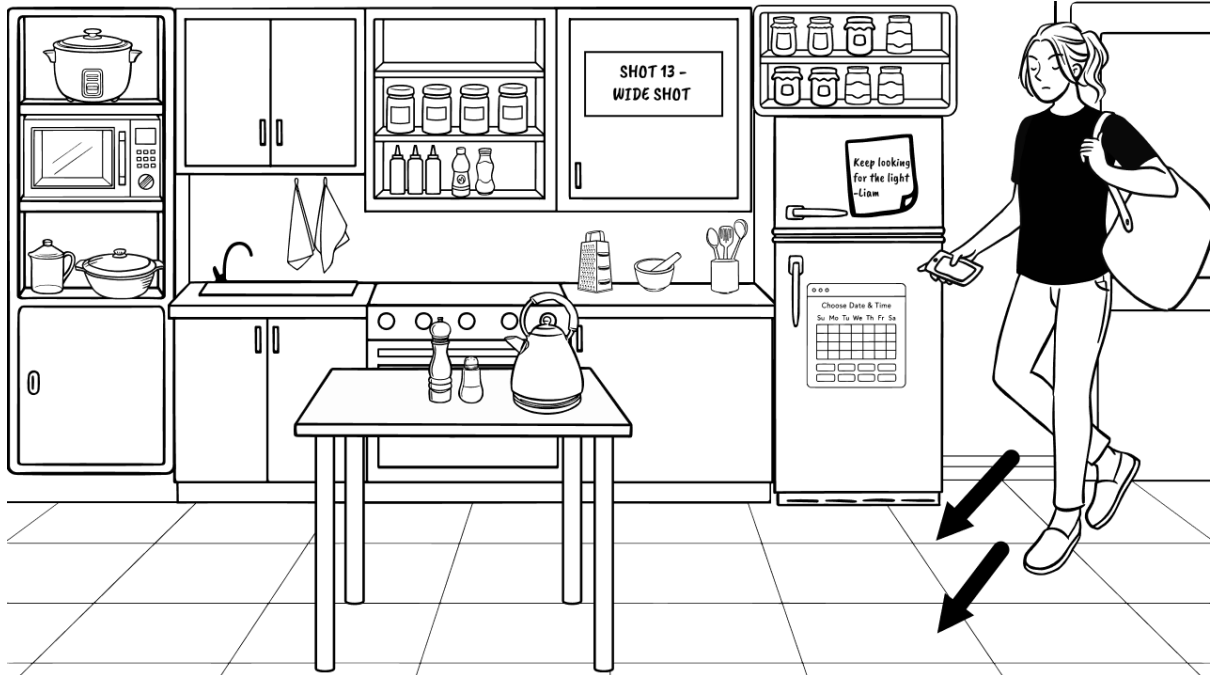


















SHOT 19 -
CLOSEUP SHOT

SLAM



Should I watch it?

SHOT 20 -
CLOSEUP SHOT



SHOT 21 -
OVER SHOLDER SHOT



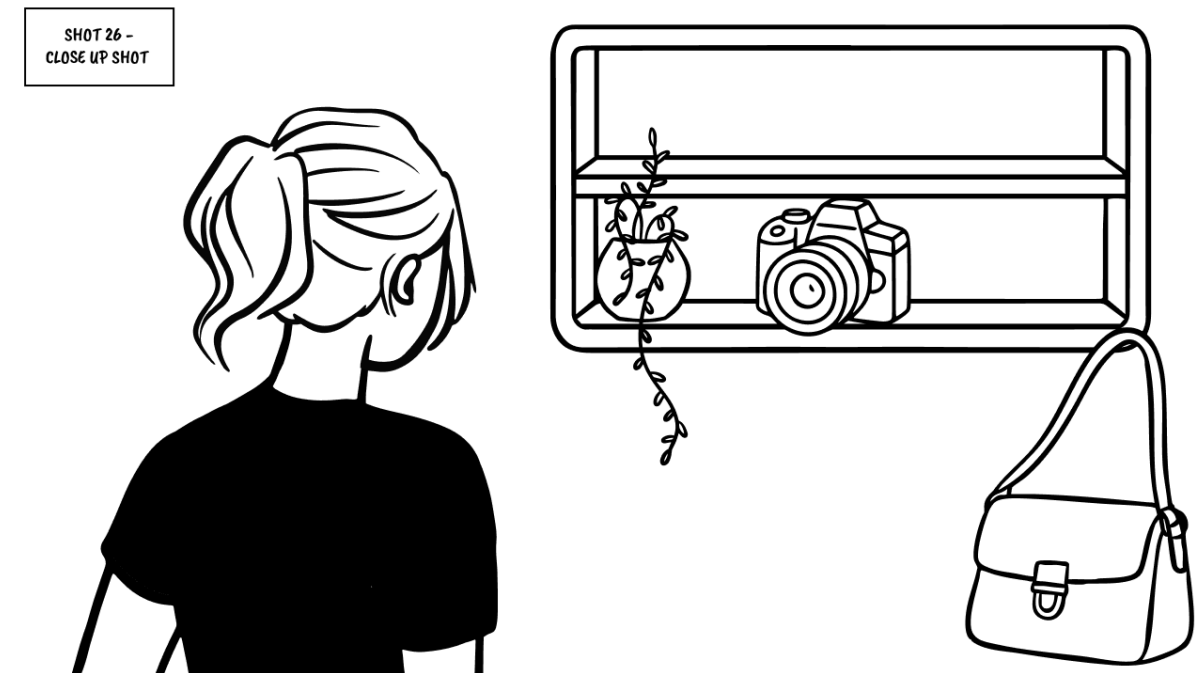
SHOT 22 -
CLOSEUP SHOT





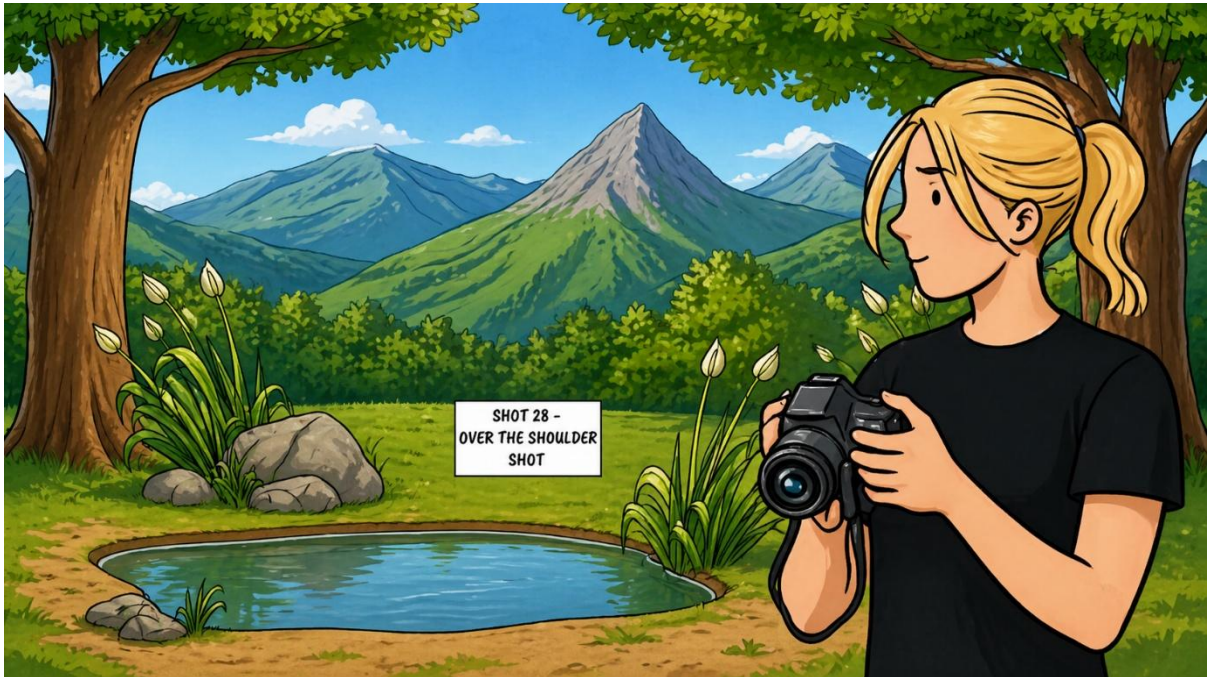


SHOT 25 -
CLOSE UP SHOT



SHOT 26 -
CLOSE UP SHOT

SHOT 27 -
CLOSE UP SHOT



SHOT 28 -
OVER THE SHOULDER
SHOT



Animatic including Sound Edit (music, copyright, voice over details)

YouTube Link: <https://youtu.be/Gz2x830qJGo>

Music used: "End Of Beginning" (Djo), covered by Kai Nutland.

Used with permission for academic purposes.

Script for Prototype to “FOCUS”

FADE IN:

INT. ELLA’S LIVING ROOM – CHRISTMAS MORNING – DAY

Warm fairy lights. A quiet hum of Christmas music in the background.

Christmas presents on the floor. LIAM stands across from ELLA who is sitting on the couch, holding his camera. He takes a picture of ELLA smiling.

Then he picks up a present from under the tree and hands it to ELLA.

LIAM (soft grin)

Alright... this one’s from me.

Ella opens it slowly. She unwraps a camera, her eyes widening.

ELLA (smiling, emotional)

seriously? This is too much.

LIAM

Nah. You deserve to remember the good stuff.

Promise to capture EVERYTHING!

ELLA

...I promise

Ella laughs breathlessly and leans over to hug him tightly. The sound of her laugh echoes—

AUDIO CUTS.

CUT TO:

INT. ELLA’S ROOM – SIX MONTHS LATER – NIGHT

Everything is dark except the faint, cold glow of the camera screen.

Ella sits alone on her bed, hair messy, eyes tired and swollen.

On the camera screen: an old clip of LIAM, smiling into the lens.

LIAM (V.O., from footage)

One day you’re gonna look back at this and see how far you’ve come.

Ella’s hand shakes as she rewinds the video again. Tears fall silently.

She whispers into the darkness:

ELLA

I miss you.

The camera beeps — a low battery warning.

CUT TO BLACK.

END.

Storyboards for Prototype to “FOCUS”



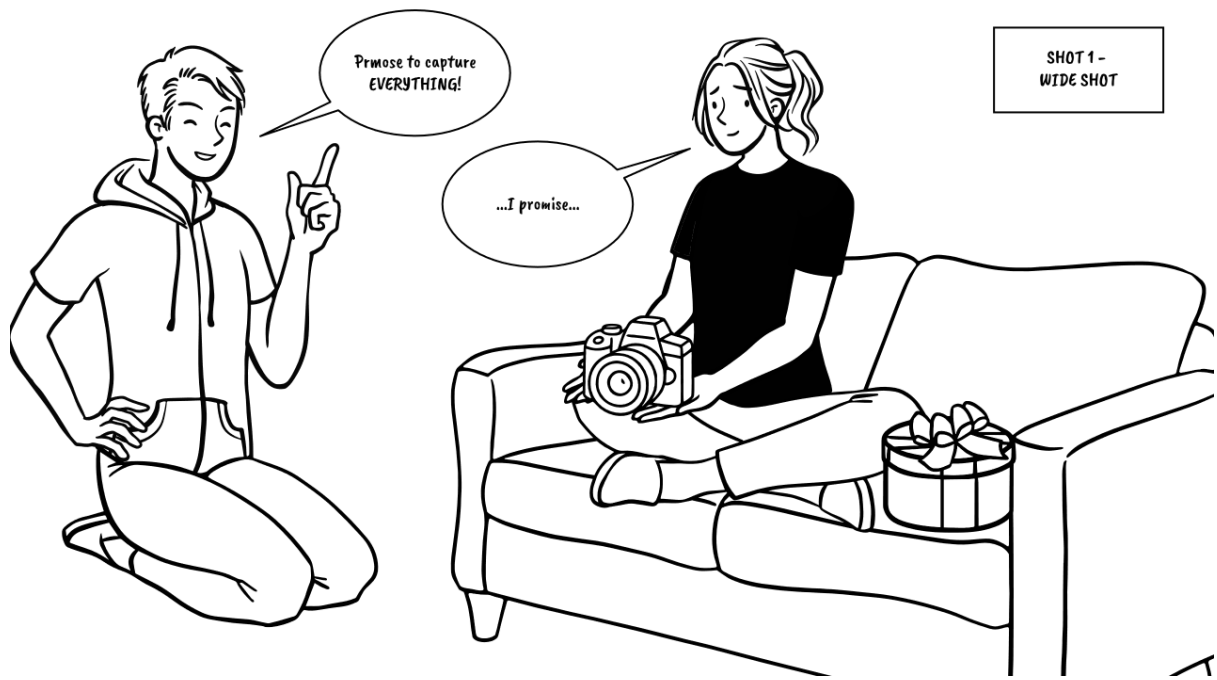
SHOT 1 -
WIDE SHOT

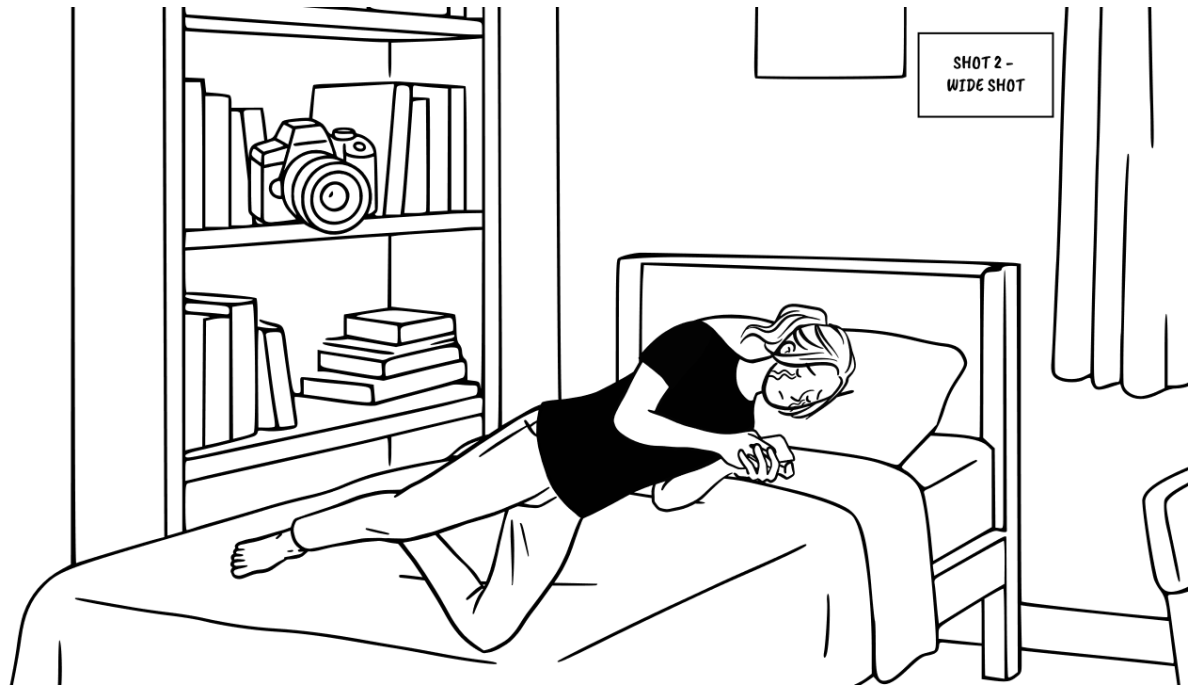


SHOT 1 -
WIDE SHOT









"Focus"

Animatic for Prototype to “FOCUS”

YouTube Link: <https://youtu.be/oZNNgJRddB8>

Trailer to “FOCUS”

YouTube Link: <https://youtu.be/5quwsee9FEY>

Thumbnail:

Created using [Canva](#).

